down, they would have lost around eighty seats. Roughly speaking, this is the effect you can attribute to the media,' was his conclusion.

Unlike Yogendra, I am not a numbers man. Nor will I hold up the CMS figures as indicative of a pro-Modi bias in the media. The fact is, Modi did become the central figure and the main talking point in this election. The BJP's great success was in making the 2014 elections truly presidential, thereby enabling Modi to set the pace and the agenda. The media was, to that extent, only mirroring a reality that existed in large parts of the country. He got disproportionate coverage because he was, after all, the newsmaker number one. And don't forget, the BJP also did remarkably well in states like Jharkhand and Chattisgarh where media penetration is much less.

What is true, though, is that the media, especially television, lost its capacity to seriously interrogate the BJP's prime ministerial candidate's leadership credentials. Modi's Gujarat model, which he offered through the election as a symbol of his success, was almost never tested on the ground. Modi said it, we believed it. As a result, we forgot a cardinal journalistic principle—the truth often nestles in shades of grey.

While Modi reaped the benefits of the media's fascination in this election, we must not forget that the TV camera's love affair with the Gandhi family was once perhaps almost as intense. For years, we tended to treat the Gandhi family with exaggerated deference, almost never seriously questioning their prolonged silence and unwillingness to open up on contentious issues, be it their relations with Bofors-accused Quattrocchi, their sources of wealth or their feudal style of decision-making. Sonia Gandhi has been in politics for almost two decades now—how many times have we really been able to quiz her? When I interviewed her in 2005, she almost walked out over a question I raised on dynasty politics. Modi has at least been subject to intense scrutiny for his role in the 2002 riots.

But in 2014, the equation dramatically changed. The same media that had once been hostile to Modi was now effectively co-opted to his side. His every virtue was extolled, the criticism was muted. By contrast, the UPA leadership had to contend with an openly adversarial media from 2009. The Gandhis were subject to searching analysis, and found wanting. The UPA-II